Philemon

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

A letter about one man, carried by the man it is about.

Onesimus was a slave who ran away from his master Philemon in Colossae.

Somewhere along the road he met Paul, who was in chains. And Onesimus came to faith.

Now Paul is sending him home.

Back to the master he wronged. With nothing to protect him but this letter.

Paul could command. He chooses to ask.

His name means useful. He was useless to you, Paul says. Now he is useful to you and to me.

Maybe he was parted from you for a little while so that you could have him back forever.

No longer as a slave. As a brother.

Receive him as you would receive me.

And if he has wronged you, or owes you anything, put it on my account.

I, Paul, write this with my own hand. I will repay it.

Twenty-five verses about forgiveness, written to a man who had every right not to forgive.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

PHILEMON - A Runaway Sent Home, Useless Made Useful, and Put It to My Account

Key Notes

- Paul writes as a prisoner, not an apostle. He opens no other letter that way. He is asking a favor as one bound man for another (Philemon 1:1, 1:9).
- Philemon lived in Colossae. Paul's letter to the Colossians names Onesimus as one of you, and Archippus too, so the two letters likely traveled together (Philemon 1:2, Colossians 4:9, 4:17).
- Apphia is often taken to be Philemon's wife, and Archippus their son, though the letter does not say so (Philemon 1:2).
- "The assembly in your house." There were no church buildings. Believers met in homes, and this home belonged to the man whose slave had run away. The whole assembly would hear the letter read (Philemon 1:2, Romans 16:5).
- "The hearts of the saints have been refreshed through you." Paul praises Philemon for the very quality he is about to ask him to use (Philemon 1:7, 1:20).
- "Though I have all boldness in Christ to command you… for love's sake I rather beg." Paul has authority and lays it down. A forgiveness that is ordered is not really forgiveness (Philemon 1:8-9, 1:14).
- "Paul, the aged" - or, by a change of one letter, Paul the ambassador. Either way he is leaning on who he is, not on what he could demand (Philemon 1:9).
- "My child, whom I have become the father of in my chains." Onesimus came to faith through Paul while Paul was in prison. Chains did not stop the work (Philemon 1:10).
- Onesimus means useful or profitable. Paul plays on it: once useless to you, now useful to you and to me. Grace made his name true (Philemon 1:11).
- "I am sending him back… my own heart." Paul sends part of himself home in Onesimus (Philemon 1:12).
- The Torah says: you shall not deliver to his master a servant who has escaped to you; let him live where he chooses, and do not oppress him. Paul does not hand Onesimus over against his will. Onesimus goes back with Paul's letter, to be received as a brother (Philemon 1:12, Deuteronomy 23:15-16).
- "I desired to keep with me." Paul wanted him to stay and would not keep him without Philemon's consent. He would not do even a good thing by taking a choice away from someone else (Philemon 1:13-14).
- "Perhaps he was therefore separated from you for a while, that you would have him forever." Joseph told his brothers: you meant it for evil, but God meant it for good. The wrong is not excused; it is redeemed (Philemon 1:15, Genesis 50:20).

- “No longer as a slave, but more than a slave, a beloved brother.” The Torah forbade making a brother serve as a slave; he was to be as a hired worker and go free at the Jubilee. Paul applies that brotherhood to a man who was not born an Israelite (Philemon 1:16, Leviticus 25:39-42).
- “Both in the flesh and in the Lord.” A brother in the flesh - in ordinary daily life in that house - and a brother in the Lord. The change was meant to show (Philemon 1:16).
- “If then you count me a partner, receive him as you would receive me.” Paul asks Philemon to see Onesimus with Paul’s face on him (Philemon 1:17).
- “If he has wronged you at all, or owes you anything, put that to my account.” Onesimus may have stolen when he ran. Paul takes the debt on himself. Isaiah: Yahweh has laid on him the iniquity of us all (Philemon 1:18, Isaiah 53:6).
- The Torah required restitution when a man had wronged another - the whole amount and a fifth more. Paul does not cancel the debt by pretending it is not there. He pays it (Philemon 1:18, Leviticus 6:4-5).
- “I, Paul, write this with my own hand: I will repay it.” A signed promissory note, in the middle of a letter. Paul usually dictated and signed at the end in his own hand (Philemon 1:19, Colossians 4:18).
- “Not to mention to you that you owe to me even your own self.” Philemon also came to faith through Paul. The man being asked to forgive a debt owes a far larger one himself - which is the point of the servant forgiven ten thousand talents (Philemon 1:19, Matthew 18:32-33).
- “Refresh my heart in the Lord.” The same word as verse 7. Paul asks Philemon to do for him what he has done for everyone else (Philemon 1:20, 1:7).
- “You will do even beyond what I say.” Some read a hint here that Paul hoped Philemon would set Onesimus free. The letter does not say it outright (Philemon 1:21).
- “Prepare a guest room for me.” Paul plans to come and see how it went. Forgiveness with a visit coming is forgiveness with accountability (Philemon 1:22).
- Mark is named among Paul’s fellow workers - the same Mark Paul refused to take on his second journey because he had deserted them. Paul knew about second chances. Later he wrote: bring Mark, for he is useful to me (Philemon 1:24, 2 Timothy 4:11).
- Demas is here a fellow worker. In Paul’s last letter Demas has left him, having loved this present world. Not every name in a greeting list finishes the race (Philemon 1:24, 2 Timothy 4:10).
- A bishop named Onesimus led the assembly in Ephesus a few decades later, according to a letter of Ignatius. Whether he was the same man is not known, but some have thought so - and that he may have helped gather Paul’s letters, including this one (Philemon 1:10).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Assembly in Your House	Philemon 1:2 • Romans 16:5 • Colossians 4:15

Topic	References
Onesimus, One of You	Philemon 1:10 • Colossians 4:9
Do Not Hand Him Over	Philemon 1:12 • Deuteronomy 23:15-16
You Meant It for Evil	Philemon 1:15 • Genesis 50:20 • Genesis 45:5
Not as a Slave	Philemon 1:16 • Leviticus 25:39-42 • Galatians 3:28
Restitution in Full	Philemon 1:18 • Leviticus 6:4-5 • Numbers 5:7
With My Own Hand	Philemon 1:19 • Galatians 6:11 • Colossians 4:18
Mark, Demas and Luke	Philemon 1:24 • Colossians 4:10-14 • 2 Timothy 4:10-11

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Liberty Proclaimed	Philemon 1:16 • Leviticus 25:10 • Isaiah 61:1
The Iniquity Laid on Him	Philemon 1:18 • Isaiah 53:6 • Isaiah 53:11
A Kinsman Who Redeems	Philemon 1:19 • Leviticus 25:47-49 • Ruth 4:9-10
The Weary Soul Refreshed	Philemon 1:20 • Jeremiah 31:25 • Psalm 23:3

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- Enduring Word - Philemon Commentary (David Guzik) - verse by verse through Paul's appeal for Onesimus
- BibleProject - Philemon Overview - a short video on forgiveness and equal partnership in the Messiah

Philemon 1 - Opening Intro

Philemon is a letter about one man, and it was carried by the man it is about.

Here is the story behind it. Philemon was a believer in Colossae. He was well off - the assembly met in his house. And he owned a slave named Onesimus.

And Onesimus ran away. Probably took something with him when he went.

And somehow - we are not told how - Onesimus ended up with Paul. And Paul was in chains. And through Paul, Onesimus came to faith.

Now Paul has a problem. He loves this young man. He calls him my own heart. He would love to keep him. But Onesimus belongs to Philemon, and Philemon is Paul's friend, and something has to be made right.

So Paul sends him home. With this letter in his hand.

Picture Onesimus walking up to that house. Knocking on the door of the man he robbed and ran from. With nothing between him and whatever comes next except this sheet of paper.

And look at how Paul writes it. He says: I could command you. I have the authority. But for love's sake, I would rather ask.

Because forgiveness you are ordered to give is not really forgiveness. It has to be chosen.

And then Paul makes a joke. Onesimus means useful. And Paul says: he used to be useless to you. Now he is useful - to you and to me.

Grace made his name come true.

And then Paul looks at the whole mess and sees God in it. Maybe he was separated from you for a little while so that you could have him back forever. No longer as a slave - as a brother.

That is Joseph standing in front of his brothers. You meant it for evil. God meant it for good.

Now the Torah already said something about this. Do not make your brother serve as a slave. He is to be like a hired worker, and go free at the Jubilee. And Paul says: Onesimus is your brother now. Both in the flesh - in the everyday life of that house - and in the Lord.

And then the heart of the letter. Receive him as you would receive me. And if he has wronged you, or owes you anything - put it on my account.

Put it on my account.

That is the gospel in five words. Isaiah 53 - Yahweh laid on Him the iniquity of us all. The debt is real. Paul does not pretend it away. He pays it.

And then he grabs the pen himself. I, Paul, am writing this with my own hand. I will repay it.

And then - gently - not to mention that you owe me your own self.

Philemon came to faith through Paul too. The man being asked to forgive a small debt owes a much bigger one himself. That is Matthew 18. The servant forgiven ten thousand talents who would not forgive a hundred denarii.

And Paul closes: prepare a guest room for me. I am coming. Which means Philemon knew Paul would see for himself how Onesimus was received.

We do not know how Philemon answered. But the letter survived. Somebody kept it. And a few decades later, the leader of the assembly in Ephesus was a man named Onesimus.

Before we read - you are in this letter twice. You are Onesimus, sent home with your debt paid by someone else. And you are Philemon, with someone at your door asking to be forgiven.

Philemon 1:1-25 (WEB)

1 Paul, a prisoner of Christ Jesus, and Timothy our brother, to Philemon, our beloved fellow worker,

2 to the beloved Apphia, to Archippus, our fellow soldier, and to the assembly in your house:[1]

3 Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

4 I thank my God always, making mention of you in my prayers,

5 hearing of your love, and of the faith which you have toward the Lord Jesus, and toward all the saints;

6 that the fellowship of your faith may become effective, in the knowledge of every good thing which is in us in Christ Jesus.

7 For we have much joy and comfort in your love, because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed through you, brother.

8 Therefore though I have all boldness in Christ to command you that which is appropriate,

9 yet for love's sake I rather beg, being such a one as Paul, the aged, but also a prisoner of Jesus Christ.

10 I beg you for my child, whom I have become the father of in my chains, Onesimus,[2]

11 who once was useless to you, but now is useful to you and to me.

12 I am sending him back. Therefore receive him, that is, my own heart,[3]

13 whom I desired to keep with me, that on your behalf he might serve me in my chains for the Good News.

14 But I was willing to do nothing without your consent, that your goodness would not be as of necessity, but of free will.

15 For perhaps he was therefore separated from you for a while, that you would have him forever,[4]

16 no longer as a slave, but more than a slave, a beloved brother, especially to me, but how much rather to you, both in the flesh and in the Lord.[5,6]

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[1] **Cross-Reference:** Romans 16:5 • Colossians 4:15 - *the assembly that is in their house, and Nymphas and the assembly in his house*

[2] **Cross-Reference:** Colossians 4:9 - *Onesimus, the faithful and beloved brother, who is one of you*

[3] **Cross-Reference:** Deuteronomy 23:15-16 - *do not deliver to his master a servant who has escaped to you, and do not oppress him*

[4] **Cross-Reference:** Genesis 50:20 • Genesis 45:5 - *you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, and God sent me before you to preserve life*

[5] **Cross-Reference:** Leviticus 25:39-42 • Galatians 3:28 - *your brother shall not serve as a slave but go free at the Jubilee, and neither slave nor free, all one*

[6] **Messianic Connection:** Leviticus 25:10 • Isaiah 61:1 - *liberty proclaimed throughout the land, and the anointed one sent to proclaim liberty to the captives*

17 If then you count me a partner, receive him as you would receive me.

18 But if he has wronged you at all, or owes you anything, put that to my account.[7,8]

19 I, Paul, write this with my own hand: I will repay it (not to mention to you that you owe to me even your own self besides).[9,10]

20 Yes, brother, let me have joy from you in the Lord. Refresh my heart in the Lord.[11]

21 Having confidence in your obedience, I write to you, knowing that you will do even beyond what I say.

22 Also, prepare a guest room for me, for I hope that through your prayers I will be restored to you.

23 Epaphras, my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus, greets you,

24 as do Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, and Luke, my fellow workers.[12]

25 The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit. Amen.

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[7] **Messianic Connection:** Isaiah 53:6 • Isaiah 53:11 - *Yahweh has laid on him the iniquity of us all, and he will bear their iniquities*

[8] **Cross-Reference:** Leviticus 6:4-5 • Numbers 5:7 - *restore what was taken in full and add a fifth, and make restitution for the guilt*

[9] **Messianic Connection:** Leviticus 25:47-49 • Ruth 4:9-10 - *a brother or close relative may redeem him, and Boaz redeeming what was Elimelech's before witnesses*

[10] **Cross-Reference:** Galatians 6:11 • Colossians 4:18 - *large letters written with my own hand, and the greeting of Paul with my own hand*

[11] **Messianic Connection:** Jeremiah 31:25 • Psalm 23:3 - *I have satiated the weary soul, and he restores my soul*

[12] **Cross-Reference:** Colossians 4:10-14 • 2 Timothy 4:10-11 - *Mark, Luke and Demas greeting the Colossians, and Demas leaving while Mark is useful for service*

Major Themes in Philemon

- A letter carried by the man it was about
- A prisoner asking, when he could command
- Forgiveness that must be chosen to be real
- Chains that did not stop a new birth
- Useless made useful, and a name made true
- Sent home to the one he wronged
- Not handed over, but sent with a plea
- Parted for a while to be received forever
- What was meant for evil, meant by God for good
- No longer a slave, but a brother in the flesh and in the Lord
- Received with someone else’s face on him
- Put it to my account: the debt acknowledged and paid
- A promise signed in his own hand
- The forgiver who owes a greater debt
- Hearts refreshed
- Forgiveness with a visit coming
- Mark, who got a second chance, and Demas, who did not finish

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May we refresh the hearts of the saints.

May we ask in love where we could command.

May we forgive because we choose to, not because we are made to.

May the useless places in us become useful in Him.

May we go back and make right what we have wronged.

May we see God’s purpose in the separations we did not understand.

May we receive as brothers those we once held as debtors.

May we receive one another as we would receive Him.

May we remember that our debt was put to His account.

May we never refuse a small debt while forgetting the great one forgiven us.

May we do even beyond what is asked of us.

May we be ready for His visit.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.